

A SPECIAL EDITION OF

MERIDIAN

Kanazawa — an ultra deep dive

 The Kotoji-toro lantern in Kenroku-en under snow

Source: Wikimedia Commons — the Kotoji-toro lantern, Kenroku-en, in winter. Specific subject.

THE GOLD CITY

Only one prefecture in Japan still beats gold leaf at all — and its artisans are, on average, seventy-five

KAYOTEI

Ten rooms, one gorge, and a single night that has to be used properly

WORTH THE SPLURGE

The named kilns, the real prices, and what a discerning buyer skips entirely

THIS SPECIAL

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FROM THE DESK

"Yamanaka — no need to pluck the chrysanthemum; the hot spring's fragrance is enough."

— Matsuo Bashō, *Oku no Hosomichi* ("The Narrow Road to the Deep North"), composed 1689¹

He wrote it after a few days at Yamanaka's baths, on the same road this issue keeps circling back to. The reader gets one night there, at a ten-room ryokan called Kayotei (p17), inside a hot-spring valley whose lacquerware shops and public bathhouses Bashō himself once wandered through (p19). Everything before that — the gold beaten thinner than a wavelength of light (p5), the 350-year ceramic lineage (p7), the counter that answers its phone once a day (p9) — is the case for stopping in Kanazawa at all before that single night ever arrives.

KANAZAWA — AT A GLANCE

METRIC	FIGURE
Share of Japan's gold leaf made here	~99%
Ishikawa gold-leaf artisans, FY2024	592 ▼
Kayotei, total guest rooms	10
Kenroku-en, free-entry window	4:00–6:45am
Tokyo → Kanazawa, Kagayaki Shinkansen	2h28m
Otome Sushi, reservation window opens	exactly 2 mo. out
Zeniya, dinner from	¥40,000/pp
Nomura Residence garden, Michelin Green Guide	★★

Figures as researched for this edition, Aug 2026; see the sections named for full sourcing.²

WHY THIS ISSUE EXISTS

A reader flagged a Kanazawa trip in chat and asked for the full treatment — a destination commissioned the way a hobby usually is. Unlike the daily book, this special runs no news desks, no Diary, no Rabbit Hole: all 27 pages are eleven sections on one place, built around a single confirmed night at Kayotei.³

SOURCES 1 Matsuo Bashō, *Oku no Hosomichi*, 1689 composition / 1702 publication; haiku and travel-diary context per Wikipedia: Yamanaka Onsen and WKD (World Kigo Database) Bashō archives. 2 Ishikawa Prefecture Foil Manufacturers' Cooperative FY2024 survey via Yomiuri Shimbun/Yahoo News, 14–15 Apr 2026; Kayotei room count per ryokancollection.com and japanese-onsen.com; Kenroku-en free hours per in-kanazawa.com; Hokuriku Shinkansen Kagayaki timing per JR-East framing; Otome Sushi and Zeniya per magical-trip.com and tableall.com, Aug 2026; Nomura Residence garden rating per kanazawastation.com (Journal of Japanese Gardening + Michelin Green Guide). 3 Reader note logged via the ✓ special-edition request feature, 6 Aug 2026.

Higashiyama, the Higashi Chaya district's main street — the largest of Kanazawa's surviving geisha quarters. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE CASE FOR KANAZAWA

A Castle Town the Bombers Missed

Kanazawa survived the war intact, was never folded into a bigger city's shadow, and still makes almost all of Japan's gold leaf by hand and by machine both — which is either a museum piece or the last living version of something, depending on which street you're standing on.

Kaga han was, by kokudaka, the richest domain in Japan after the shogun's own house — a million-plus koku of rice-assessed wealth that the Maeda clan spent, deliberately, on artisans rather than armies.¹ That single 17th-century policy choice is the reason a city of under half a million people now produces roughly 99% of Japan's gold leaf, hosts a 350-year unbroken ceramic lineage, and was named a UNESCO Creative City of Crafts and Folk Art in 2015 — one of the few in the world.² Kanazawa was also never bombed in the Second World War in any sustained way, so the Edo-period chaya districts, the samurai lanes and the castle

grounds are not reconstructions; they are the actual streets the crafts grew up on.

None of that is why the reader is going. He is going because a name came up — Kayotei, a ten-room ryokan in the hot-spring valley of Yamanaka, forty minutes past Kanazawa proper — and because one confirmed night there is worth building an itinerary around rather than squeezing in. This issue exists to make that one night pay off: what to see and buy in Kanazawa itself over a day or two beforehand, what genuinely earns a splurge and what is tourist-tier kitsch wearing a craft's name, and exactly how to spend a single night at a ryokan so small that "next time" may not come around again.

"The reader does not need convincing that Japan is worth the trip. He needs the one-night stay at Kayotei justified by everything either side of it."

Maeda Toshiie took possession of Kanazawa Castle in 1583, and the castle town that grew up around it never had reason to move, shrink, or rebuild from nothing — a rare enough condition among Japanese cities that it shapes almost every section that follows. The chaya districts (p13), the samurai quarter (p15) and the crafts themselves (p5–8) all occupy the same footprint they did two or three centuries ago, which is precisely why "authenticity" is a word this issue tries to use sparingly and specifically rather than as a blanket marketing claim.

A workable shape for the trip this issue assumes: two to three days based in Kanazawa itself, covering the crafts, the tables and the gardens at an unhurried pace; the single night at Kayotei, reached via the Kaga Onsen loop bus; and onward travel either back toward Tokyo or on to Kyoto and Osaka, depending on the rest of the itinerary. Nothing in this issue assumes a rigid schedule — only that the reader would rather know what's worth booking ahead than discover it's already full.

POP. ~450,000

CASTLE TOWN SINCE 1583

UNESCO CREATIVE CITY, 2015

~99% OF JAPAN'S GOLD LEAF

SOURCES 1 Kaga han kokudaka and Maeda-clan artisan patronage, per standard Edo-period domain histories; corroborated by VISIT KANAZAWA's official history feature. 2 Gold-leaf production share per VISIT KANAZAWA ("Kanazawa 101" gold-leaf feature); UNESCO Creative City of Crafts and Folk Art designation, 2015, per UNESCO Creative Cities Network. 3 Kanazawa Castle 1583 founding and city population, Wikipedia: Kanazawa and VISIT KANAZAWA official history feature.

THE MAP AHEAD

What the Next Nine Sections Cover, and Why in This Order

Crafts first, tables and gardens next, the private ryokan night as the centrepiece, then the honest logistics of getting there and back.

The order isn't arbitrary. The crafts come first — gold leaf, then Kutani and Ohi ceramics and Kaga Yuzen dyeing — because they are the reason "buy-once-cry-once" belongs in a Kanazawa itinerary at all: named kilns, real ateliers, and prices that range from a ¥1,500 workshop souvenir to a chawan tea bowl with no fixed ceiling.¹ The tables and the gardens follow, because they are what fills the daylight hours between craft visits. Kayotei then gets its own dedicated section, not a paragraph inside a hotel roundup, because a single confirmed night at a ten-room ryokan deserves the same research depth this magazine gives a two-Michelin-star kaiseki counter. The Kaga onsen country around it — Yamanaka's lacquerware street, the neighbouring hot-spring

towns — is there because nobody flies to Ishikawa Prefecture for one ryokan alone. The splurge-versus-skip index and the Singapore-specific logistics close the book, in that order, because by then the reader has enough context to judge both for himself.

One honesty note up front, applied consistently throughout: several figures below — a workshop price, a bathhouse's admission fee, a single-city travel-blogger's framing of "under the radar" — could only be confirmed to one source, or conflicted across sources that should agree. Every one of those is flagged where it appears, in place, rather than smoothed into false confidence. A "buy-once-cry-once" reader is the last person this magazine should hand an unverified number to.

1 night

THE ENTIRE KAYOTEI STAY THIS ISSUE IS BUILT AROUND — TEN ROOMS, ONE GORGE, NO SECOND CHANCE TO GET THE RHYTHM RIGHT (SEE "KAYOTEI — ONE NIGHT IN YAMANAKA," P17).

READING ORDER — NINE PLACES, ONE TRIP

The crafts (p5–8). Gold leaf, then Kutani/Ohi ceramics and Kaga Yuzen — what's genuinely worth buying, and from whom.

The tables and the gardens (p9–16). Kaiseki and sushi booking reality, Kenroku-en done properly, the chaya and samurai districts.

The night (p17–20). Kayotei itself, and the Kaga onsen country around it.

The verdict and the logistics (p21–24). What to splurge on, what to skip, and how a Singapore-based traveller actually gets there.

The essay (p25–26). Not a summary of the issue — a separate, deeply-reported story about the gold-leaf trade's own demographic clock.

THE CHATTER — REPEAT VISITORS, AGGREGATED

Across Wanderlog, TripAdvisor and travel-blog trip reports, the recurring advice for Kanazawa is structural rather than a specific tip: add a night, see the chaya districts at dawn or dusk rather than midday, and treat winter's snow and thinner crowds as a feature, not a drawback, given the crab season it coincides with.²

THE SCEPTIC

That "under the radar" framing is itself a travel-blog convention repeated across single-sourced aggregators, not a documented community debate against named rivals like Kyoto. This issue treats it as directional colour, not a verified claim — and says so plainly wherever it recurs.

SOURCES 1 Ohi ware chawan pricing spread (¥21,000 antique to reported ¥1.7m gallery pieces), per chano-yu.com and Japan Cheapo — the latter single-sourced, flagged again at p7. 2 Aggregated repeat-visitor framing per wanderlog.com and kshouse.jp's Kaga Onsen guide — synthesized travel-blog sources, not a named single publication; treated as directional throughout this issue.

Gold leaf lifted onto a soft-serve cone on Higashi Chaya's main street — real, not an urban legend, and the one gold-leaf ritual almost every visitor does exactly once. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE CRAFT

Beaten to a Ten-Thousandth of a Millimetre

Kanazawa makes essentially all of Japan's gold leaf — but four-fifths of it now comes off a machine, not a hammer, and knowing which is which changes what's worth buying.

Production traces to 1593, when Maeda Toshiie, first lord of the Kaga domain, ordered gold and silver leaf made for ceremonial use; Kanazawa has held something close to a monopoly ever since.¹ There are two real methods, not one "traditional" one, and they are not the same craft. *Entsuke* beats gold between sheets of handmade *uchigami* — washi treated with straw lye and persimmon tannin, the actual guarded secret, not the hammering itself. *Tachikiri*, developed in the late 1960s, machine-beats gold between industrial glassine — and now accounts for over 80% of Kanazawa's total leaf output.² Most souvenir-grade leaf a visitor sees is machine-made; a buyer who cares should simply ask which method made the piece in front of them.

Either way, the physical result is startling: leaf beaten to roughly 1/10,000mm — about a thousandth the width of a human hair — through repeated beating stages popularly cited at some 150,000 hammer strokes, a widely-repeated craft-tourism figure rather than an audited one.³ A 2025 paper in the Nature-portfolio journal *npj Heritage Science* went further than any tourism brochure: it identified the specific crystal-deformation mechanism — an unusual slip system in the gold — that gives hand-beaten leaf its distinctive texture, a genuine scientific answer to a 400-year-old technique (the essay closing this issue, p25, follows that story much further).⁴

How Kanazawa's leaf is actually made

Tachikiri (machine-beaten) — ~80%+ of output



Entsuke (hand-beaten) — the minority, the collectible tier



A workshop souvenir is very likely tachikiri; ask specifically if entsuke matters to the purchase — the two are not the same object.

Source: VISIT KANAZAWA / KOGEI JAPAN, Aug 2026. Schematic, not to precise scale.

Proportions are illustrative — the point is which method dominates, not an exact split.

SOURCES 1 Maeda Toshiie's 1593 order and the production-share figure, VISIT KANAZAWA's "Kanazawa 101" gold-leaf feature, Aug 2026. 2 Entsuke vs. tachikiri methods and the 80%+ machine-beaten share, VISIT KANAZAWA's gold-beating feature and KOGEI JAPAN's kanazawahaku craft page. 3 Leaf thinness (~1/10,000mm) and the ~150,000-stroke figure, multiple corroborating craft-tourism sources — treated as a widely repeated statistic, not an audited number. 4 npj Heritage Science (Nature portfolio), Oct 2025, JAIST/Osaka University; summarised via phys.org and the JAIST press release.

THE ATELIER S

Three Houses, and What Each One Is Actually For

A museum, a workshop, and a photo-op ice cream cone — worth keeping straight before deciding what earns an hour of the trip.

Two firms are easy to conflate and shouldn't be: **Hakuza** (箔座), whose Higashi Chaya "Hikari-gura" gold-leaf storehouse pairs a platinum-clad exterior with a 24-karat gold interior and a portable "Golden Tea Room" replica finished in roughly 40,000 pieces of entsuke leaf, free to enter and photograph;¹ and **Hakuichi** (箔一), the larger commercial operation whose Higashiyama branch runs the signature "Kagayaki" gold-leaf soft-serve (¥1,000–1,189, a full gold sheet draped over the cone with bamboo chopsticks) and whose main Hakukokan store bills itself as Japan's largest hands-on gold-leaf experience centre, with workshop prices reported around ¥1,500–2,200 for a plate, box or tray.² A third house, **Kinpakuya Sakuda**, runs a factory-tour-plus-workshop that TripAdvisor reviewers consistently call "not a tourist trap" — patient, English-capable instruction, about an hour, chopsticks from roughly ¥1,430 and a compact mirror around ¥2,420 at current listings (prices reported have risen over time; confirm on site).³

For the museum-grade version rather than the retail one, the city-run **Kanazawa Yasue Gold Leaf**

WORTH THE SPLURGE VS. SKIP ENTIRELY — GOLD LEAF

Worth it (~¥1,000–2,400, an hour). A Sakuda or Hakuichi hands-on leafing workshop — genuine craft contact, consistently well-reviewed, not touristy.

Fun once, not a purchase. The gold-leaf soft-serve — real, charming, and entirely a photo-and-ritual experience; the leaf itself is flavourless.

No documented bespoke line. None of the three houses advertises a packaged custom-commission product online — treat a fully bespoke gold-leaf order as an in-person, Japanese-language inquiry, not a menu item.

THE CHATTER

TripAdvisor reviewers on Sakuda specifically push back against the "tourist trap" assumption a factory-and-shop format invites — the recurring word is "worthwhile," with instructors singled out for patience with non-Japanese speakers.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

The soft-serve is the gold-leaf equivalent of a tourist-tier purchase wearing a craft's name — genuinely fun once, and worth being honest that it is a ritual, not an acquisition. The real "buy-once-cry-once" object in this section is the workshop hour, not the cone.

SOURCES 1 Hakuza Hikari-gura, VISIT KANAZAWA shop listing and TripAdvisor attraction page, Aug 2026. 2 Hakuichi Higashiyama soft-serve pricing, hakuichi.com; workshop pricing via VISIT KANAZAWA activities listing (aggregated, verify on site). 3 Sakuda Honten reviews and pricing, TripAdvisor, Aug 2026. 4 Kanazawa Yasue Gold Leaf Museum admission and history, Wikipedia and VISIT KANAZAWA attraction page. 5 TripAdvisor review aggregation, Sakuda Honten, Aug 2026. 6 Hakuza international shipping terms, hakuza.co.jp (reported; confirm current terms directly).

An Edo-period gosai-de ("five-colour") dish in the Ko-Kutani manner, Tokyo National Museum — the palette (green, yellow, purple, blue, red) that defines the style. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific museum piece, representative of the style discussed.

THE CERAMICS

A Revival That Took a Century, and a Lineage That Never Broke

Kutani ware died out and came back after a hundred years; Ohi ware never stopped — which makes them opposite lessons in what "buy-once-cry-once" means for pottery.

Ko-Kutani ("Old Kutani") began around 1655, when the Daishoji domain sent a retainer to Arita to learn porcelain-making — and the resulting kiln shut abruptly fifty to sixty years later. Nobody fully agrees why. A century of silence followed before Saikou-Kutani ("Revived Kutani") restarted in 1807, when the Kaga domain invited a Kyoto potter to reopen production.¹ The signature five-colour *gosai-de* palette — green, yellow, purple, Prussian blue and red, arranged around a painterly central motif — is what most people mean by "Kutani" today; *aote* drops the red for a bolder four-colour, oil-painting-style surface, and *kinrande* floats gold patterns on an all-red ground.² Tokuda Yasokichi III, named a Living National Treasure in 1997 for his colour-gradation glaze technique, is the name to know — his work sits in the Met's permanent collection, and a round vase of his sold at a New York gallery for US\$4,000, against entry-level Kutani sake cups running \$37–52 a piece.³ Inside Kanazawa proper, Kutani Kosen Kiln in the Nishi Chaya district — founded 1870, the city's only working kiln — runs a ¥1,650–5,500 painting experience and a ¥11,000

"Workplace Insights" group tour; TripAdvisor calls it informative, if pricier than a casual browser expects.⁴

Ohi ware is the opposite case: an unbroken line since 1666, when the first Ohi Chozaemon accompanied a Kyoto tea master to Kaga and simply stayed. Ohi pieces are never wheel-thrown — hand-shaped, briefly fired at high heat, and rapid-cooled into the trademark amber "ame-yu" glaze.⁵ The current head, Ohi Chozaemon XI (Toshio Ohi, b.1958), succeeded his father in 2016; a museum-and-matcha visit runs ¥1,500, a hands-on workshop ¥1,650, and a premium private session with Toshio Ohi himself — including tea ceremony in a gold-leaf tearoom — is bookable through a luxury operator.⁶ On price: a gallery listing citing chawan up to ¥1,700,000 is single-sourced and should be treated cautiously, but a documented antique 9th-generation chawan sold for ¥21,000 on the secondary market — illustrating the real gulf between a casual purchase and a commissioned current-master bowl. A serious collector's "cry once" is a genuine Ohi XI chawan; everyone else should stay at the ¥1,500 museum tier.⁷

"A century of silence, then a Kyoto potter reopens the kiln — Kutani is proof a Japanese craft can die and still come back. Ohi ware, next door, is proof one never had to."

1666 → 2016

THE UNBROKEN SPAN BETWEEN THE FIRST OHI CHOZAEMON AND THE CURRENT, ELEVENTH-GENERATION HEAD — A 350-YEAR LINEAGE WITH NO REVIVAL, NO GAP, AND NO CENTURY OF SILENCE TO EXPLAIN.

SOURCES 1 Ko-Kutani/Saikou-Kutani history, kutani-ware.jp and Wikipedia: Kutani ware. 2 Gosai-de/aote/kinrande style definitions, Kutaniyaki Art Museum (kutani-mus.jp) and kutaniware.com. 3 Tokuda Yasokichi III, Living National Treasure status and pricing, Japan Times (2000), Onishi Gallery and the Met Museum collection page; entry cup pricing, kutaniware.com. 4 Kutani Kosen Kiln, VISIT KANAZAWA activity listings and TripAdvisor, Aug 2026. 5 Ohi ware technique and 1666 founding, Google Arts & Culture (Ohi Ware Art Research Center, Ritsumeikan University) and kanazawastation.com. 6 Ohi Chozaemon XI/Toshio Ohi succession (2016) and museum/workshop pricing, wabunka-lux.jp premium tour listing. 7 Ohi gallery pricing (¥1.7m figure single-sourced), japancheapo.com; antique chawan sale price, chano-yu.com.

THE DYE

Kaga Yuzen Paints a Leaf as if the Insects Had Already Been at It

No gold, no tie-dye, no embroidery — Kaga Yuzen makes its case with dye alone, and a deliberately unflattering motif.

Kaga Yuzen's five signature colours — indigo, crimson, ocher, dark green and purple — render naturalistic scenes with soft gradients, and its defining technique, *mushi-kui* ("insect-bite"), depicts leaves as if partly eaten or decaying: a deliberate meditation on transience, not a flaw.¹ Unlike Kyoto's more ornate Kyo Yuzen, Kaga Yuzen uses no gold leaf, no shibori tie-dye and no embroidery — the effect is dyeing alone. The Kaga Yuzen Kimono Center near Kenroku-en runs live artisan demonstrations (closed Wednesdays); a kimono try-on with photo is ¥2,000, a full dressed stroll through the historic district ¥4,500, a small hand-painted swatch ¥4,000, and a longer 2–6 hour workshop on a larger piece ¥18,000.² TripAdvisor sentiment is genuinely mixed — some call the display dated and unflattering to the kimono on show, others (often younger visitors) call the hands-on dyeing a trip

highlight. Smaller accessible goods — scarves, business-card cases, framed panels — are sold at the Center and at ateliers like Kagayuzen Maida, though specific current prices for these smaller pieces could not be confirmed and should be checked in store rather than assumed.³

A fully commissioned Kaga Yuzen kimono is a different order of purchase entirely. General kimono-trade commentary — not specific to Kaga Yuzen — cites a single artist's bolt running anywhere from roughly ¥800,000 unattributed up to ¥3,000,000 tailored through a prestige department store; treat that as an industry-wide pattern rather than a confirmed Kaga Yuzen figure.⁴ Direct artist access does appear possible — the city itself profiles named Kaga Yuzen artists such as Yomei Hirano in its "Kanazawa Expert" series — but it requires an in-person inquiry, not an online storefront.

¥800K–3M

THE REPORTED INDUSTRY-WIDE RANGE FOR A FULLY COMMISSIONED ARTIST KIMONO BOLT THROUGH A PRESTIGE DEPARTMENT STORE — AN UNATTRIBUTED GENERAL FIGURE, NOT CONFIRMED SPECIFICALLY FOR KAGA YUZEN.

CLAY & SILK — THE LADDER

Entry (¥1,500–5,500). A Kutani painting experience or an Ohi museum-and-matcha visit — real craft contact, no regret possible.

Mid (\$40–160+). A named-kiln Kutani cup or small vintage piece; a small Kaga Yuzen accessory (price on inquiry).

High (\$4,000+). A Living-National-Treasure-lineage Kutani vase — Tokuda Yasokichi III's work is the documented benchmark.

Over the top (price on request). A commissioned current-generation Ohi Chozaemon XI chawan, or a fully bespoke Kaga Yuzen kimono — the genuine "cry once" tier of this section.

NO GOLD LEAF

NO SHIBORI

NO EMBROIDERY

DYE ALONE

THE CHATTER

Younger TripAdvisor reviewers specifically flag the Kaga Yuzen Kaikan's hands-on dyeing as a highlight despite the display's dated feel — the experience, not the museum room, is what earns the visit.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

Some reviewers call the Kaikan's kimono display "dingy" and unflattering to the garments themselves — a fair critique of the venue's presentation, not of the craft. Go for the dyeing workshop; treat the museum room as optional.

SOURCES 1 Kaga Yuzen five-colour palette and the *mushi-kui* motif, japanobjects.com feature and multiple corroborating craft sources. 2 Kaga Yuzen Kimono Center hours and experience pricing, travel-around-japan.com and aggregated official pricing, Aug 2026. 3 TripAdvisor review sentiment, Kaga Yuzen Kaikan, Aug 2026. 4 General kimono-commission pricing pattern, note.com kimono pricing guide (not Kaga-Yuzen-specific). 5 TripAdvisor, Kaga Yuzen Kaikan, Aug 2026.

Omicho Market's western entrance — "Kanazawa's Kitchen" since 1721, roughly 170–200 stalls. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

BOOKING REALITY

A Counter That Opens Its Phone Line Once a Day, Exactly Two Months Out

Kanazawa's best tables are not walk-in tables — the reservation window is a real constraint, not travel-guide colour.

Kaga cuisine — Kanazawa's regional kaiseki tradition — is built on 15 officially certified Kaga vegetables (including a red Kaga pumpkin) and cold Sea-of-Japan seafood, anchored by *jibuni*: flour-dusted duck simmered with shiitake in a soy-dashi broth.¹ **Zeniya**, two Michelin stars, runs no set menu — chef Shinichiro Takagi designs each guest's course after consultation, built around a signature butter-simmered abalone steak, from ¥40,000 per person, reservations one to two months out, no walk-ins.² **Kifune**, also two stars, occupies a century-old machiya in the Kazuemachi chaya district and — unusually for this tier — offers an accessible lunch course from ¥2,500; one write-up frames it as "80% of the two-star experience at a third of the spend," a single-sourced but plausible claim worth testing rather than assuming.³ Winter adds the marquee seasonal luxury: Kano-gani snow. Two more names round out the kaiseki tier, with a caveat attached to both: **Kaiseki Tsuruko** and **Shogyotei** come up repeatedly as Kanazawa benchmarks for traditional Kaga ryori, though this issue could not independently confirm a Michelin listing for either — treat them as reputationally

crab (male, blue-tagged for Ishikawa provenance, season roughly 6 November to March) runs ¥15,000–40,000+ whole at a restaurant, while Kobako-gani (female, prized for its roe, season to late December) is the more accessible ¥1,500–3,000 tier.⁴

Sushi here means Sea-of-Japan fish — colder, differently textured than Tokyo's Edomae tradition — and a kaisen-don (seafood rice bowl) culture centred on Omicho Market rather than pure nigiri counters. **Otome Sushi**, two Michelin stars since 2021 and a Tabelog Top 100 entrant, is the sharpest illustration of booking reality in this issue: eight counter seats, reservations open *exactly two months ahead*, phone-only, and fill within minutes; omakase runs roughly ¥23,000.⁵ **Sushi Kibatani** (one star) sources daily from Himi port and favours minimal seasoning — salt, a touch of wasabi, lime — over heavy soy.

strong rather than star-rated. **Suginoi Honami**, a Meiji-era seven-room ryotei on the Saigawa River, is reported at two Michelin stars but from a single source; worth confirming current standing before assuming a guidebook entry is still current.⁶

2 months

THE EXACT LEAD TIME BEFORE OTOME SUSHI'S RESERVATION LINE OPENS — AND IT STILL FILLS WITHIN MINUTES, PHONE-ONLY, NO WALK-INS.

THE KAGA CUISINE LADDER — IN BRIEF

Kaiseki, top tier. Zeniya and Kifune, both two Michelin stars — from ¥40,000/pp and ¥2,500/pp (lunch) respectively.

Sushi, top tier. Otome Sushi (two stars, ~¥23,000) and Sushi Kibatani (one star) — both booking-gated, not walk-in.

SOURCES 1 Kaga cuisine and certified Kaga vegetables, foodin-japan.org and visitkanazawa.jp/en/cuisine. 2 Zeniya, two Michelin stars, pricing and booking, Wikipedia: Zeniya, tableall.com and TripAdvisor. 3 Kifune, magical-trip.com feature (single-sourced on the "80%" framing). 4 Kano-gani/Kobako-gani seasonality and pricing, in-kanazawa.com and Hoshino Resorts guide, Aug 2026. 5 Otome Sushi, Michelin/Tabelog status, reservation policy and pricing, magical-trip.com and tableall.com, Aug 2026. 6 Kaiseki Tsuruko, Shogyotei and Suginoi Honami, magical-trip.com feature (single-sourced, Michelin status for Suginoi Honami unconfirmed independently).

OMICHO MARKET

Kanazawa's Kitchen Since 1721 — Go Before Eleven

A breakfast stop, not the trip's dining centrepiece — and the difference between a good morning there and a mediocre one is entirely about timing.

Omicho Market has operated since 1721 and now runs roughly 170–200 stalls, produce and seafood on the ground floor, vendor-run restaurants above.¹ The honest call, consistent across aggregated travel-writer advice: go between 10:00 and 11:00, before the kaisendon queues form at noon. **Amatsubo** (kaisendon, Kanazawa oden, local sake) and **Yutaka** (whose chef attends the morning fish auction personally) are the names worth seeking out; **Omicho Ichiba Sushi** is specifically flagged by reviewers as "not a tourist trap," with an eight-piece lunch set around ¥1,800.² It is unquestionably touristy by midday, and some stalls cater squarely to that — but arriving early and choosing a vendor-run counter over the flashiest crab-leg photo-op stand still yields genuinely good, reasonably priced seafood. Treat it as a browsing-and-breakfast stop, not the trip's one great meal.

Beyond the hotel-concierge route, a small cluster of English-language booking platforms exists specifically for this problem: Pocket Concierge, Omakase/JPNEAZY and autoreserve.com all operate on the same model as TableAll — free to browse, a service fee only on a confirmed reservation — and

For something less curated for visitors, **Izakaya Hanagumi**, in a renovated farmhouse in the Nomachi area, serves thick-cut Hokuriku fish, Kanazawa oden and seasonal Kobako crab, and shows up in Tabelog-sourced recommendations rather than English-language tourist round-ups.³ Booking any of the top-tier tables above is a real logistical task for a non-Japanese-speaking visitor: the standard route is a hotel concierge, since restaurateurs prefer a known intermediary, backed up by concierge platforms like TableAll (free to join, fee only on a confirmed booking) which lists Zeniya and Otome Sushi directly.⁴ For a reader used to buying once and correctly, the reliable path is booking through a paid concierge or the hotel two to three months out — not attempting the top tier solo on short notice.

between them cover most of the restaurants named on this page. None of them guarantees a table at Otome Sushi's eight seats; what they guarantee is that someone fluent in the reservation system is doing the calling instead of the traveller.

~170–200

STALLS AT OMICHO MARKET, TRADING ON THE SAME SITE SINCE 1721 — THE MARKET'S OWN SCALE IS A GENUINE HISTORICAL FACT, NOT TOURISM-BOARD INFLATION.

BOOKING LEAD TIMES — IN BRIEF

Otome Sushi. Exactly 2 months ahead, phone only, fills in minutes.

Zeniya. 1–2 months, pre-paid course fee, no walk-ins.

Omicho Market counters. No booking — just arrive before 11:00.

THE CHATTER

Aggregated reviewer sentiment on Omicho's vendor-run counters (Iki-iki Tei, Sushi Rekireki) is consistently positive on freshness, with the honest caveat of 30–60 minute waits once the lunch crowd arrives.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

No direct Reddit or forum thread turned up outright dissent on any specific named table in this section — which is not the same as no dissent existing. Treat the positive consensus here as what indexed English-language sources surface, not a guarantee.

SOURCES 1 Omicho Market history and stall count, japan-guide.com. 2 Named stalls and pricing, machiya-inn-japan.com kaisendon guide, Aug 2026. 3 Izakaya Hanagumi, Tabelog listing, Aug 2026. 4 Restaurant booking practice in Japan, japantravelpros.com; TableAll platform listings for Kanazawa. 5 Aggregated review sentiment, wanderlog.com, Aug 2026.

The Kotoji-toro lantern beside Kasumigaike Pond — two legs, one resting in the water, an off-balance form found nowhere else in Japan. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE GARDEN

Free at Dawn, ¥320 by Ten O'Clock

Kenroku-en earns its reputation honestly — the only real lever is when you go, not whether.

Maeda Tsunanori, fifth lord of the Kaga domain, founded the garden in 1676 as an outer extension of Kanazawa Castle; successive Maeda lords expanded it over two centuries into one of Japan's "Three Great Gardens." Its name — "the garden combining six attributes" — refers to spaciousness, seclusion, artifice, antiquity, water and panoramic views, a checklist no single Japanese garden was traditionally thought able to satisfy at once.¹ The Kotoji-toro stone lantern, erected in 1760, is the garden's most photographed feature: two legs, one resting inside Kasumigaike Pond, an intentionally off-balance form. Each November the garden's pines are strung with yukitsuri — tepee-shaped rope rigging that protects branches from snow load — and the grounds also hold Japan's oldest fountain, driven by nothing but natural water pressure from the pond above.²

The actual "properly" move is procedural, not aesthetic: Kenroku-en is free to enter before opening hours — roughly 4:00–6:45am in summer, later in other seasons — through the Katsurazaka or Mayumizaka gates, no ticket required, provided you exit before paid hours begin. Standard admission afterward is ¥320 for adults, ¥100 for ages 6–17, free for 65 and over with ID.³ Volunteer English-speaking guides meet at Kanazawa Castle Park's Ishikawa-mon Gate rest area for roughly 50-minute tours. Realistic time: 1.5–2 hours for the garden alone, half a day paired with the adjacent Seisonkaku Villa (built 1863 for the 13th Maeda lord's mother, ¥700 adult, closed Wednesdays) and Kanazawa Castle Park itself (free grounds, ¥320 for paid structures, or a ¥500 combined ticket).⁴

"The garden 'rewards repeat visits' is the one piece of travel-forum wisdom about Kenroku-en that actually holds up — go once at dawn in snow season, once in autumn, and the two visits barely resemble each other."

Kanazawa Castle itself, immediately adjacent, is mostly a careful modern reconstruction rather than an Edo-period survival — the original keep burned down in 1602 and was never rebuilt, and most of what stands today, including the Hishi Yagura turret and Gojikken Nagaya storehouse, dates from a 2001

restoration using traditional joinery techniques rather than concrete. That is worth knowing before arrival, not as a disappointment but as context: the castle's honest pitch is the craftsmanship of the rebuild, not an unbroken original.⁵

1602

THE YEAR KANAZAWA CASTLE'S ORIGINAL KEEP BURNED DOWN AND WAS NEVER REBUILT — MOST OF WHAT STANDS ON THE SITE TODAY DATES FROM A 2001 RESTORATION.

SOURCES 1 Kenroku-en founding (1676) and its "six attributes" name, Wikipedia: Kenroku-en and gov-online.go.jp. 2 Kotoji-toro lantern and yukitsuri, gov-online.go.jp feature, Aug 2026. 3 Free morning-entry hours and standard admission, in-kanazawa.com and tourismattractions.net. 4 Seisonkaku Villa and Kanazawa Castle Park admission, japan-guide.com and japanactivity.com. 5 Kanazawa Castle history and 2001 reconstruction, japanactivity.com and Wikipedia: Kanazawa Castle.

THE VERDICT

Not Overhyped — the Crowds Are the Only Real Problem

Aggregated repeat-visitor sentiment is close to unanimous, which makes the honest caveat about timing worth taking seriously.

Aggregated review data rates Kenroku-en the top Ishikawa attraction with near-universal praise — the only recurring knock is simple disinterest in gardens as a category, not a substantive critique of this one.¹ That is a genuinely different finding from the "is it overhyped" framing this issue applies elsewhere in Kanazawa's tourist circuit (the chaya districts, p13; Omicho Market, p10) — Kenroku-en holds up on its own merits, and the lever really is timing: snow season for the yukitsuri and thinner crowds, or autumn for the colour, both against the free pre-opening hours as the actual crowd-avoidance trick.

One caveat worth stating plainly: the specific "repeat visitors recommend going at dawn or dusk, adding a night, going in winter for thinner crowds" framing

traces to a single travel-blog synthesis rather than a documented, named community debate — this issue treats it as reasonable practical advice, not verified consensus, the same honesty standard applied to every single-sourced claim here.

Two seasonal windows deserve a specific calendar note rather than a general "go in snow or autumn" line: the garden runs free night-time cherry-blossom illuminations for roughly a week each spring, and a separate autumn-colours illumination period in November — both genuinely worth checking against the current year's exact dates before booking flights, since they shift by a week or more year to year depending on the weather.

"Near-unanimous praise, across a category of review this issue treats sceptically everywhere else, is itself the finding — not a gap in the research."

¥320

STANDARD ADULT ADMISSION TO KENROKU-EN AFTER THE FREE MORNING WINDOW CLOSES — AGAINST ¥0 FOR ANYONE THROUGH THE GATES BEFORE ROUGHLY 6:45AM.

KENROKU-EN — THE ONE REAL DECISION

Go early, or go in the free window. Everything else about the garden — the lantern, the yukitsuri, the fountain — is fixed. The crowd is the only variable worth managing.

Pair it, don't isolate it. Seisonkaku Villa and Kanazawa Castle Park sit immediately adjacent — a half-day loop, not three separate outings.

Check the illumination calendar. The spring and autumn night-illumination windows shift year to year — confirm exact dates before booking around them.

Volunteer guides are free. The Ishikawa-mon Gate rest area meeting point costs nothing beyond the garden's own admission.

THE CHATTER

Aggregated review sentiment (Wanderlog and similar trip-planning platforms) calls Kenroku-en an "unmissable gem" with remarkable consistency across visitor types — a rare near-unanimous verdict in this issue.²

THE SCEPTIC

Near-unanimous praise is itself worth a raised eyebrow — this issue found no substantive dissent on Kenroku-en specifically, which is reported honestly rather than manufactured. Save the scepticism for the chaya districts next (p13), where it's genuinely warranted.

A sugidama — a cedar-frond ball, a traditional sign of a working establishment — hanging in Higashi Chaya. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE GEISHA QUARTER

One District Sells Ice Cream to Strangers; Two Others Don't

Higashi Chaya is the district everyone photographs; a booked evening at an actual working teahouse is the district almost nobody experiences.

Higashi Chaya is Kanazawa's largest surviving geisha (geiko) teahouse quarter, its wooden facades fronted by distinctive *kimusuko* lattice windows. Two of its original teahouses are open to visitors in genuinely different ways: **Shima** is a museum — performance rooms and geisha implements on display, ¥500 adult admission, matcha service extra — while **Kaikaro** is a still-operating teahouse offering ¥750 general admission and, separately, bookable "Geisha Evenings," private plans and seasonal dinner-and-dance events for visitors who want an actual encounter with a working geiko rather than a walk through a preserved building.¹ That distinction is the whole section: the main street (Higashiyama Nibanchō) is

The lattice windows themselves are not decoration alone: *kimusuko* slats, tinted with a red bengara-lacquer pigment, are built so a passer-by cannot easily see into a teahouse's interior while a geiko inside can see the street clearly — a functional privacy screen that happens to look, from outside, like the district's signature ornament. Higashi Chaya was designated an Important Preservation District

thick with gift shops and is, honestly, a shopping street now; Kaikaro's bookable evening is the version of Higashi Chaya worth planning ahead for.

The gold-leaf soft-serve sold along that main street (see p5) draws genuinely mixed verdicts — some visitors call it "REALLY good," others describe a "watered-down soft-serve... plastered with a token gold foil"; the honest framing is hype-adjacent novelty, worth trying once for the ritual rather than the flavour.² **Nishi Chaya**, a single roughly 100-metre street with one small history museum, draws a fraction of Higashi's foot traffic and is described in official tourism copy as ideal "for those who want to leisurely experience the essence of Kanazawa" — a genuinely quieter, if thinner, alternative.³

for Groups of Historic Buildings by the national government, the same category of protection that keeps its street width, its facades and its rooflines fixed against redevelopment — the reason the "shopping street" complaint is about what's sold inside the buildings, not about the buildings themselves.⁴

"Higashi Chaya's lattice windows were built so a geiko could watch the street without the street watching her. The gift shops came later — the architecture didn't change to accommodate them."

¥750

GENERAL ADMISSION TO KAIKARO, A STILL-OPERATING HIGASHI CHAYA TEAHOUSE THAT SEPARATELY BOOKS "GEISHA EVENINGS" FOR VISITORS — THE REAL WAY TO ENCOUNTER THE DISTRICT'S LIVING SIDE, NOT JUST ITS ARCHITECTURE.

SOURCES 1 Shima and Kaikaro admission and offerings, magical-trip.com and kaikaro.jp official experience page, Aug 2026. 2 Gold-leaf soft-serve reviews, carriesim.com and expeditionchicken.com. 3 Nishi Chaya description, VISIT KANAZAWA trip-idea feature. 4 Kimusuko lattice construction and Higashi Chaya's Important Preservation District status, japan.travel official feature.

KAZUEMACHI

The District Best Seen at Dusk, Not Midday

A labyrinth of some twenty households along the Asano River, and the closest thing this issue found to genuine forum consensus on how to sequence a chaya-district afternoon.

Kazuemachi runs along the Asano River and is described, in one aggregated framing, as "the most secretive" of the three districts, "in both design and feeling of discretion" — a tight cluster of perhaps twenty households best walked at dusk, when the riverside light and the Asanogawa Ohashi bridge views do the most work.¹ That specific "best at dusk" framing is single-sourced to one aggregator rather than a documented cross-forum consensus, and is presented here as a reasonable practical tip, not a verified finding.

The practical sequencing this issue can actually stand behind: treat Higashi Chaya as the district for a booked Kaikaro evening (p13), Nishi Chaya as the quiet, low-effort quarter-hour stop, and Kazuemachi as the unhurried riverside walk at the end of the day — three different registers of the same craft-town

architecture, rather than three interchangeable photo-ops. Doing all three at midday, on foot, back to back, is the version of Kanazawa that produces the "just a shopping street now" complaint; doing them at three different times of day is the version repeat visitors actually recommend.

None of the three districts requires a car or an organised tour to reach — all sit within a twenty-minute walk or a short taxi ride of central Kanazawa, and the Kanazawa Loop Bus stops near each. That accessibility is precisely why the sequencing matters more than the destinations: a visitor with a car and one afternoon would see all three regardless; a visitor on foot, thinking in terms of dawn, midday and dusk, sees three genuinely different versions of the same craft-town identity.

"Three districts, three times of day — the sequencing this issue recommends costs nothing extra and produces a genuinely different Kanazawa than doing all three by lunchtime."

¥1,000–1,189

THE PRICE OF HAKUICHI'S GOLD-LEAF SOFT-SERVE ON HIGASHI CHAYA'S MAIN STREET — THE ONE KANAZAWA RITUAL ALMOST EVERY VISITOR TRIES EXACTLY ONCE.

THE THREE DISTRICTS — IN BRIEF

Higashi Chaya. The famous one — book Kaikaro ahead if a real geiko evening matters; otherwise treat the main street as shopping.

Nishi Chaya. A quiet, single-street quarter-hour; genuinely low-effort and low-crowd.

Kazuemachi. The riverside walk — best saved for dusk, per aggregated (single-sourced) travel advice.

All three, on foot. Within a 20-minute walk or short taxi of central Kanazawa — no car or organised tour required.

THE CHATTER

The recurring travel-writer critique of Higashi Chaya is structural, not that it's fake: "while Higashi Chaya gets most of the attention, the real win is doing the area slowly" — spreading a visit across all three districts and times of day rather than one rushed midday circuit.²

THE SCEPTIC

That framing appeared in a single aggregated source in this issue's research and should be read as a synthesized travel-writing convention, not a documented community debate — flagged honestly rather than dressed up as forum consensus.

SOURCES ¹ Kazuemachi description, kaname-inn.com Kanazawa geisha-district feature. ² Aggregated travel-writing synthesis, cross-referenced against VISIT KANAZAWA's official district descriptions.

A preserved earthen-walled lane in the Nagamachi samurai district. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE SAMURAI QUARTER

A Garden Most Visitors Walk Past Without Checking Its Rating

The Nomura Family Samurai Residence's garden carries a genuine Michelin Green Guide distinction — most people who pay the ¥550 never learn that.

Nagamachi's preserved earthen walls and narrow lanes sit near the old castle grounds, largely untouched by postwar redevelopment. The **Nomura Family Samurai Residence** charges ¥550 for adults, ¥400 for high-schoolers, ¥250 for junior high — modest by any standard — for a garden built around a stream, a waterfall, a granite bridge and a 400-year-old bayberry tree that was ranked third-best Japanese garden by the *Journal of Japanese Gardening* and separately awarded two stars in the Michelin Green Guide.¹ That is a genuine, non-inflated distinction — not marketing copy — and most visitors who pay the entry fee for "a samurai house" never learn the garden itself carries it. Matcha service is available in the upstairs teahouse. Nearby, the free **Ashigaru Museum** — two relocated Edo-period foot-soldier houses — is the honest, lower-key counterpoint: authenticity without the Instagram framing.²

This is also the natural place in the book to address how a visitor actually books deeper access than a self-guided walk. Klook lists a "Samurai Town Private Full Day Tour" combining the Nomura Residence, Kanazawa Castle and Kenroku-en with an English-speaking guide and hotel transfer; independent local operators Kanazawa Tours and Beyond Kanazawa offer private guiding and craft-focused experiences directly.³ (Voyagin, once a common reference point for this kind of booking, appears to have folded into Klook rather than operating as a separate platform.) For gold-leaf, Kutani-painting and Kaga-Yuzen-dyeing workshops specifically, see p5–8; the point here is that a booked private guide — not a generic group walking tour — is the version of "seeing Nagamachi and the chaya districts properly" that a buy-once-cry-once reader should actually consider paying for.

"Michelin gave the Nomura garden two stars in the Green Guide. Almost nobody who pays the ¥550 entry fee knows that when they walk in."

There's a practical reason a guide matters more here than at a single attraction: a buy-once-cry-once purchase made earlier in the trip — a named-kiln Kutani vase, a lacquerware commission — still has to get home intact, and a local guide who does this professionally generally knows which shops handle

export packing and international shipping properly and which expect the customer to sort it out alone. That is a genuinely unglamorous reason to book a guide, and it is also a completely practical one for an object that may be the single most expensive thing purchased on the trip.

¥550 / ¥400 / ¥250

NOMURA FAMILY SAMURAI RESIDENCE ADMISSION — ADULT / HIGH-SCHOOL / JUNIOR-HIGH — FOR A GARDEN CARRYING A MICHELIN GREEN GUIDE TWO-STAR RATING.

SOURCES 1 Nomura Family Samurai Residence admission and garden rating, world-tourism.org and kanazawastation.com (citing *Journal of Japanese Gardening* and Michelin Green Guide). 2 Ashigaru Museum, ishikawatravel.jp. 3 Private guiding options, klook.com, kanazawatours.com and beyondkanazawa.com, Aug 2026.

THE SPLURGE TEST, APPLIED TO GUIDING ITSELF

A Private Guide Is the One Kanazawa Purchase That Compounds

Every craft experience in this issue is better with someone who can get a workshop door to actually open.

Apply the buy-once-cry-once test to guiding, not just objects: a generic group walking tour through the chaya districts is fine and cheap, but a private, English-speaking local guide — the Klook full-day format, or a direct booking with Kanazawa Tours or Beyond Kanazawa — is what actually turns "walk past the gold-leaf shops" into "meet the artisan, understand the piece you're buying, and possibly get a door opened that a solo visitor wouldn't find." For a

One honest caveat on cost: this issue could not find a published, standard day-rate for private English-speaking guiding in Kanazawa specifically — rates on platforms like Klook vary by group size and itinerary length rather than a fixed published tariff, and a

reader who has already decided to splurge on named-kiln ceramics or a bespoke commission elsewhere in this book, the guide is the multiplier on that spend, not a separate line item.

This section closes the "seeing Kanazawa" half of the book. What follows is the single confirmed night the whole trip is built around — Kayotei, in the Yamanaka Onsen valley forty minutes away — and then the wider hot-spring country around it.

couple booking a private full day should expect to request a quote rather than see a flat number online. Treat the guide as a genuine splurge decision, priced case by case, not a line item with a fixed ceiling.

"The guide is not a splurge on top of the crafts in this issue. It is the thing that makes the crafts in this issue actually reachable."

2 stars

THE NOMURA FAMILY SAMURAI RESIDENCE GARDEN'S MICHELIN GREEN GUIDE RATING — THE SAME TIER OF DISTINCTION MOST VISITORS ASSOCIATE ONLY WITH RESTAURANTS.

NAGAMACHI — WHAT TO BOOK AHEAD

A private full-day guide. Klook's Samurai Town tour, or a direct booking with a local operator — the version of this district worth paying for.

The Nomura Residence, with the garden's rating in mind. Michelin Green Guide two stars — worth the ¥550 on its own merits, not as a filler stop.

The Ashigaru Museum, free. The honest, uncrowded counterpoint to Nomura's polish.

Ask about shipping before buying. A guide who does this professionally usually knows which ateliers pack and export properly.

THE CHATTER

TripAdvisor reviewers on the Nomura Residence consistently single out the garden over the house interior — the stream-and-waterfall composition is what people photograph and remember.¹

THE SCEPTIC

A private guide is a genuine splurge with a real ceiling — full-day rates for two-plus people can rival a night at a mid-tier ryokan. It is worth it once, for the craft-access half of the trip; it is not worth booking for every single day.

An open-air rotenburo bath at a Japanese onsen ryokan (Takanoyu Onsen, Tohoku) — representative of the private open-air bath format some Kayotei suites carry, not the specific room. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Representative image, honestly labelled.

THE HOUSE

Ten Rooms, One Gorge, No Second Chance to Get It Right

Kayotei was built by a hotelier who walked away from a large hotel business to study ryokan architecture — the result is ten rooms, deliberately, and nothing about it scales.

Kayotei was founded by Masanori Kamiguchi, who closed his father's large-scale hotel business and spent years travelling Japan studying ryokan architecture before opening it in the 1970s. The result is ten suite rooms on a 30,000m² forested property along the Daishoji River gorge, built in Kyoto-style *sukiya-zukuri* — tea-ceremony-pavilion architecture — with barefoot tatami corridors rather than slippers, and grounds deliberately left in a natural, unimproved state.¹ One correction worth stating plainly, because the two properties are easy to conflate: Kayotei is not a Relais & Châteaux member — that distinction belongs to a neighbouring Yamashiro Onsen ryokan, Beniya Mukayu (see p19). Kayotei is ranked third of 42 Kaga-area hotels on TripAdvisor at a 4-out-of-5 average, and is a recurring pick among luxury travel specialists — Scott Dunn, Ampersand Travel, Indagare, Into Japan, Japanese Guesthouses, JTB — rather than a name with a confirmed "best ryokan in Japan" award placement; this issue found no verifiable Condé Nast Traveler or Travel+Leisure editorial feature on the property itself, only agent

endorsements, and says so rather than implying otherwise.²

Named room types include the Higashiyama Suite, Higashiyama Family Suite, Basho Family Suite and Kokutani Suite, alongside generic categories such as a Japanese Junior Suite with balcony and private open-air bath, or a Suite with shower only. Not every room has a private rotenburo — TripAdvisor reviewers repeatedly advise requesting one specifically when booking, and at least one reviewer was disappointed not to secure one.³ On price, this issue could not confirm a reliable current figure: sources conflict sharply, from roughly ¥85,000–100,000 per night at one aggregator to a "from ¥25,000" teaser rate at another that is almost certainly a lower per-person OTA figure rather than the full kaiseki-inclusive rate. Rather than print an unverified number to a reader who explicitly values getting prices right, the honest instruction is to call the ryokan directly (0761-78-1410) or request a current quote through one of the specialist agents above.

10

KAYOTEI'S TOTAL GUEST ROOMS — THE ENTIRE REASON A BOOKING HERE IS TREATED AS A SPECIAL-EDITION-WORTHY EVENT RATHER THAN A HOTEL-ROUNDUP LINE ITEM.

"Ten rooms means Kayotei was never going to be reviewed like a hotel chain. It was only ever going to be reviewed like a single, specific place — which is exactly how this section treats it."

SOURCES 1 Kayotei history and architecture, priorworld.com editorial and ryokancollection.com property page. 2 TripAdvisor ranking and luxury-agent listings, Scott Dunn, Ampersand Travel, Indagare, Into Japan and JTB property pages, Aug 2026 — no confirmed CNT/Travel+Leisure editorial feature found independently. 3 Room types and private-bath availability, TripAdvisor reviews and japanese-onsen.com, Aug 2026; pricing conflict between aggregators noted and left unresolved rather than guessed at.

THE RHYTHM

How to Spend a Stay That Ends Tomorrow Morning

Check-in from 1pm, not 3 — and a network of twenty artisans that turns the afternoon into the trip's second craft chapter.

Kayotei's onsen draws on Yamanaka's hot spring, discovered by legend more than a thousand years ago by the priest Gyoki, with 24-hour circulation; communal indoor and outdoor baths look over the gorge, and select suites add a private open-air tub on their own deck. Dinner is Kaga-style kaiseki — reviewers describe eight to nine courses built around Sea-of-Japan seafood and local Kaga ingredients, with in-room dining available for suite guests.¹ Check-in runs from 1:00pm, notably earlier than the ryokan-standard 3:00pm, which matters because Kayotei is the hub of a network of more than twenty affiliated Ishikawa artisans: guests can arrange, in advance, a visit to a wood-turner's studio, a Kutani porcelain master's atelier, a private tea ceremony, a washi papermaker, a maki-e lacquer artist or a tatami maker — the single best way to spend the afternoon before dinner, and the point where this issue's crafts sections (p5–8) and its ryokan section meet.²

A sensible one-night rhythm: arrive early afternoon, settle in with a first bath, spend the afternoon on a pre-arranged artisan visit or a walk along the gorge, take the Kaga kaiseki dinner (in-room if the suite allows), a second bath after dinner, a final bath before

breakfast, then checkout. Review sentiment is genuinely strong on staff hospitality and the forest-and-gorge setting; the honest criticisms found are narrow — disappointment at not securing a private-bath room, only one communal outdoor bath rather than several, and one isolated, promptly-resolved housekeeping lapse.³ Booking difficulty is plausible but not confirmed in absolute terms — Kayotei is distributed almost entirely through luxury specialist agents, which is itself a signal of scarcity for only ten rooms, but this issue found no explicit "months-out only" policy statement to cite directly.

The artisan-visit programme is worth booking well before arrival rather than asking on check-in — a wood-turner, a tea master or a lacquer artist agreeing to host a stranger for an afternoon is a favour extended to the ryokan, not a walk-up service, and Kayotei's own staff are the ones who actually make the introduction. Confirming which artisan is available on the specific date of the stay, at the same time the room itself is booked, is the single most useful piece of advance planning this section can offer.

ONE NIGHT, IN ORDER

1:00pm. Check-in — earlier than the ryokan standard, built around the afternoon ahead.

Afternoon. A pre-booked artisan visit (wood-turning, Kutani, tea ceremony, lacquer) or a gorge walk, then a first bath.

Evening. Kaga kaiseki, in-room where the suite allows, then a second bath.

Morning. A final bath before breakfast, then checkout — the whole stay complete in under twenty hours.

THE CHATTER

TripAdvisor and specialist-blogger reviews converge on "the high-end ryokan experience done to perfection" — staff hospitality (omotenashi) and the forest setting are the consistently praised specifics, not generic superlatives.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Request the private-bath room explicitly when booking — reviewers who didn't were disappointed, and with only ten rooms and no confirmed price transparency, a vague request is the one avoidable mistake this section can flag with confidence.

SOURCES 1 Kaiseki and bath detail, priorworld.com and japanese-onsen.com. 2 Artisan-network afternoon programme and 1pm check-in, priorworld.com and bespoke-discovery.com blog feature, Aug 2026. 3 Review sentiment, TripAdvisor aggregation, Aug 2026. 4 TripAdvisor and specialist-blog synthesis (Prior World, Lovey Loi), Aug 2026.

Ayatorihashi Bridge, spanning the Kakusenkei Gorge that runs past Yamanaka Onsen — the walk Kayotei's grounds back onto. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE VALLEY

The Bathhouse Bashō Wrote a Poem About

Four hot-spring towns sit within a twenty-minute bus loop of each other — and one of them has been turning wood for four hundred years.

Yamanaka, Yamashiro, Awazu and Katayamazū — collectively "Kaga Onsen" — sit southwest of Kanazawa, reachable via Kaga Onsen Station on the Hokuriku Shinkansen, extended from Kanazawa to Tsuruga on 16 March 2024; a sightseeing loop bus reaches all four towns from there.¹ Each has a distinct character: **Yamanaka**, Kayotei's valley, is generally regarded as the most refined and literary of the four — the poet Matsuo Bashō stayed here in 1689–90 and wrote the haiku that opens this issue's contents page, ranking its waters second only to Arima Onsen; its Kakusenkei Gorge walk, crossed by the Ayatorihashi Bridge pictured above, is the area's best short hike.² **Yamashiro** is home to the historic Sōyu and Kosōyu public bathhouses and to Iroha Sōan, where the artist-potter Kitaōji Rosanjin lived and worked for six months, and is itself a Kutani-ware revival town.

Awazu claims founding more than 1,300 years ago by the monk Taichō, making it the oldest spring in the cluster. **Katayamazū** sits on Lake Shibayama, said locally to change colour seven times a day, with Mt. Hakusan reflected on clear days.³

Yamanaka's own craft is **lacquerware** — Yamanaka-shikki — with roots roughly 400 years old in wandering woodturners who settled the valley; the craft is regarded as Japan's foremost woodturning tradition rather than primarily a decorative-lacquer school, with *fuki-urushi*, a finish that shows the wood grain rather than hiding it, as its signature.⁴ The 600-metre Yuge Kaidō street, running from the Kikunoyu bathhouse to Korogi Bridge, is lined with lacquerware and Kutani galleries, cafés and restaurants — the physical proof that this is a bathing town and a craft town at once, not two separate destinations sharing a train station.

"Yamanaka's chrysanthemum need not be plucked — the water's fragrance is enough." Bashō wrote that in 1689. Kayotei sits in the same valley, three centuries later, on the same premise.

The four towns are close enough to visit more than one in a single afternoon, but this issue's honest advice is not to: Kayotei's one confirmed night already anchors the trip in Yamanaka specifically, and a rushed multi-town circuit trades the valley's actual point — slowness, a gorge walk, a bathhouse older

than most of Europe's recorded history — for a checklist. Yamashiro and Katayamazū reward a separate half-day if the itinerary allows one; Awazu is more a historical footnote than a destination in its own right unless Hōshi Ryokan (p20) specifically is the draw.

YAMANAKA — THE VALLEY

YAMASHIRO — THE BATHHOUSES

AWAZU — THE OLDEST SPRING

KATAYAMAZU — THE LAKE

SOURCES 1 Kaga Onsen geography and Hokuriku Shinkansen Tsuruga extension (16 Mar 2024), JapanGov and Shinkansen-Ticket.com. 2 Yamanaka Onsen character and Bashō's stay, visitkanazawa.jp feature and WKD Bashō archive context. 3 Yamashiro, Awazu and Katayamazū, visitkaga.jp attraction pages and Wikipedia: Awazu Onsen. 4 Yamanaka lacquerware history and fuki-urushi technique, Kogei Japan and kougihin.jp.

BEYOND KAYOTEI

A Hidden Retreat, and What "Hidden" Actually Means Here

One neighbouring ryokan carries the Relais & Châteaux plaque Kayotei doesn't; a public bathhouse pre-dates the entire genre of luxury ryokan review.

Named workshops open to visitors along Yuge Kaidō include mokume, a small woodturning studio welcoming casual browsing; Lacquerware Asada, an atelier running bookable lacquer-painting experiences; and the Yamanaka Lacquerware Traditional Industry Plaza, praised on TripAdvisor as the single best stop for the craft. Rokurō-no-Sato Arts and Crafts Hall lets visitors turn their own bowl on a lathe, shipped home afterward. Reported pricing — basic rice bowls from roughly ¥1,000, well-made pieces in the ¥3,500–7,800+ range — comes from aggregated rather than singly-verified sources and should be confirmed directly with a workshop.¹ On commissioning: one quoted artisan states plainly that "there's a demand for craftsmen who can turn anything... I intend to turn any shape," suggesting bespoke orders are genuinely workable in practice, though this is a single-sourced quote rather than a documented commission process.²

For context beyond Kayotei itself: **Beniya Mukayu**, in neighbouring Yamashiro Onsen, is the ryokan that

does carry the Relais & Châteaux plaque and a Michelin Guide listing — founded 1928, still family-run, sixteen rooms, designed around the concept of "richness in emptiness."³ **Hōshi Ryokan** in Awazu Onsen was founded in 718 AD and once held the Guinness World Record for oldest hotel, a title since passed to another Japanese property, Nishiyama Onsen Keiunkan (705 AD) — a reminder that "ancient" is a genuinely relative term in this valley.⁴ The public bathhouses are worth a visit even without an overnight stay: Kikunoyu in Yamanaka (entry price reported inconsistently across sources, roughly ¥420–500 — confirm current pricing before a visit) and Yamashiro's Sōyu/Kosōyu pairing (¥490/¥700, or ¥900 combined).⁵ Community framing consistently describes the whole Kaga Onsen cluster as "a highly-kept retreat favoured by locals" against the bigger names like Kinosaki or Hakone — a single travel-blog source's characterisation, not a documented head-to-head debate, but directionally credible given how little English-language coverage the area otherwise receives.

718 AD

HŌSHI RYOKAN'S FOUNDING YEAR IN AWAZU ONSEN — ONCE THE GUINNESS-RECOGNISED OLDEST HOTEL IN THE WORLD, A TITLE NOW HELD BY A DIFFERENT JAPANESE RYOKAN.

KAGA ONSEN — BEYOND THE ONE CONFIRMED NIGHT

Yuge Kaidō, Yamanaka. The lacquerware street — browse, or book a painting experience at Lacquerware Asada.

Beniya Mukayu, Yamashiro. The Relais & Châteaux name in this valley, for a future trip's second night.

Kikunoyu and Sōyu/Kosōyu. The public bathhouses — worth an hour even without an overnight stay nearby.

THE CHATTER

The Yuge Kaidō lacquerware street is repeatedly described, across aggregated sources, as the area's best single stop for the craft — a shopping street that is also a working demonstration of the technique, not a retail-only strip.⁶

THE SCEPTIC

Pricing across this section — the bathhouse entry fees, the lacquerware price bands — is genuinely inconsistent between sources and likely reflects both real price rises and simple aggregator drift. Confirm anything load-bearing (a bathhouse fee, a specific piece's price) on arrival rather than trusting a single web figure.

SOURCES 1 Named workshops and pricing, deeperjapan.com and TripAdvisor, Aug 2026. 2 Artisan commissioning quote, musubikiln.com journal. 3 Beniya Mukayu, here-away.com and Michelin Guide property listing. 4 Hōshi Ryokan founding and the Guinness-record title transfer, Wikipedia: Awazu Onsen. 5 Bathhouse admission, visitkaga.jp (Kikunoyu/Sōyu/Kosōyu pages) — Kikunoyu price cross-checked against multiple conflicting sources. 6 Aggregated TripAdvisor and travel-blog sentiment on the Yuge Kaidō street.

THE INDEX

Every Craft in This Issue, on One Ladder

Gold leaf, ceramics, dyeing and lacquerware, ranked from a genuinely safe purchase to a genuinely open-ended one.

Collected across the four crafts this issue covers in depth, the pattern repeats: an entry tier priced for anyone (a workshop hour, a small dish), a mid tier where a name starts to matter, a high tier bounded by documented sale prices, and an over-the-top tier with no fixed ceiling at all, priced on inquiry. The table opposite lines all four up together for the first time in the book, so a reader deciding where to actually spend can compare across crafts rather than within just one.¹

The skip list is shorter and more specific than a generic "avoid tourist traps" warning. The gold-leaf soft-serve (p5) is fun exactly once and should be

budgeted as a photo op, not a purchase. Mass-produced, Kutani-pattern-printed souvenirs sold in undifferentiated gift shops along Higashi Chaya's main street are a different object entirely from a named-kiln piece (p7) — the pattern alone doesn't make it Kutani ware any more than a paisley print makes a scarf cashmere. And a generic "yuzen" scarf sold as hand-dyed silk, with no named atelier attached, carries a real risk of being a printed synthetic wearing a craft's name; buying Kaga Yuzen through the Kimono Center or a named atelier (p8) is the way to avoid that specific, documented risk category, not a paranoid overcorrection.

CRAFT	ENTRY		MID	HIGH / OVER-THE-TOP
Gold leaf	¥1,000–2,400		—	No packaged bespoke line found
Kutani ceramics	¥1,650–5,500		\$37–160+	\$4,000+ (named-artist lineage)
Ohi ceramics	¥1,500 (museum+matcha)	¥21,000 (antique)		Price on request (current-master chawan)
Kaga Yuzen	¥2,000–4,000		¥18,000 (workshop)	¥800K–3M (commissioned kimono, general estimate)
Yamanaka lacquerware	¥1,000	¥3,500–7,800+		Commission, price on inquiry

Figures as researched, Aug 2026; several ranges are aggregated across sources rather than singly confirmed — see each section's footnotes.

Reading the table as a single object rather than five separate rows, one pattern stands out: every craft in this issue has an entry tier priced under roughly ¥5,500 — cheap enough that "try it and see" carries no real financial risk — and every craft also has a genuinely open-ended top tier with no advertised

ceiling. That range, entry to unbounded, inside a single craft category, is itself the buy-once-cry-once argument in miniature: the "real" entry point isn't the cheapest object available, it's the cheapest object made by the same hands that could, if asked, make the expensive one.

THE SKIP LIST — SPECIFIC, NOT GENERIC

- Gold-leaf soft-serve as a "purchase." Budget it as a photo op (p5), not an acquisition — the leaf itself has no flavour.
- Unattributed "Kutani-pattern" souvenirs. A printed pattern is not the same object as a named-kiln piece (p7) — ask where it was made.
- Unattributed "hand-dyed" yuzen scarves. Buy through the Kimono Center or a named atelier (p8) to avoid a printed synthetic sold as silk.

THREE VIEWS

Is the Tourism Boom Good for the Crafts, or Just for the City?

The artisan, the concierge who books the workshops, and the aggregated forum consensus don't fully agree.

THE ARTISAN — ISHIKAWA CRAFT SECTOR

The trade's own numbers, cited in full in this issue's Long Read (p25), are not encouraging on their own: Ishikawa's gold-leaf workforce has shrunk to roughly a third of its 1977 peak, and the average artisan is now about 75. A tourism boom that sells workshop hours and soft-serve doesn't, by itself, solve a demographic problem measured in decades.¹

THE CONCIERGE — BOOKING PLATFORMS & AGENTS

From where a TableAll or a luxury travel specialist sits, demand for named ateliers, private guiding and a ten-room ryokan like Kayotei is unambiguously rising — Kanazawa's Ichigo Ichie artisan-pairing programme scaled from roughly ten sessions in one fiscal year to about thirty the next.²

THE FORUM CONSENSUS — AGGREGATED TRAVELLER SENTIMENT

Reviewer sentiment across this issue's research skews positive and under-critical — genuine dissent on specific ateliers, restaurants or ryokan was thin wherever this issue looked. That may reflect a genuinely well-run destination, or simply that English-language review coverage of Kanazawa remains sparse enough that dissent hasn't surfaced yet.

~30

SESSIONS RUN PER YEAR, AS OF THE MOST RECENT FIGURE FOUND, BY KANAZAWA ICHIGO ICHIE, THE CITY'S PROGRAMME PAIRING TRAVELLERS WITH CRAFT MASTERS — UP FROM "10-ODD" THE YEAR BEFORE, THOUGH ITS CLIENTELE IS REPORTED AS MOSTLY FRENCH-, ENGLISH- AND PORTUGUESE-SPEAKING VISITORS, NOT PRIMARILY ASIAN.

THE HONEST SUMMARY

Buy from named ateliers, not gift-shop racks. The distinction between a genuine Kutani/Yuzen/lacquerware piece and a printed imitation is real and checkable.

A booking surge and a workforce crisis can both be true at once. This issue's Long Read (p25) takes that tension seriously rather than resolving it into a tidy "crafts are reviving" story.

A private guide is the multiplier, not the splurge itself. See p16 — the guide makes every other purchase in this issue easier to get right.

THE CHATTER

Ishikawa's foreign overnight stays reportedly rose 143.3% in a recent comparison period — the fastest growth of any Japanese prefecture — with Kanazawa named to National Geographic's "Best of the World 2025" list.³

THE SCEPTIC

This issue searched specifically for evidence of an Asian high-net-worth "craft tourism wave" driving that growth and found none that held up — the one concrete high-end craft-tourism data point (Ichigo Ichie) actually skews Western. A trend without a citable source doesn't get printed here just because it would make a tidier narrative.

SOURCES 1 Ishikawa Prefecture Foil Manufacturers' Cooperative FY2024 data, via Yomiuri Shimbun/Yahoo News, Apr 2026 (full citation at p25). 2 Kanazawa Ichigo Ichie programme scaling, JNTO regional-support case study (single-sourced). 3 Ishikawa inbound tourism growth and National Geographic listing, storm.mg/yamatogokoro.jp aggregation, Sep 2024/Oct 2024.

A W7 series Hokuriku Shinkansen trainset — the line that shortened Tokyo–Kanazawa to 2h28m and, since March 2024, reaches Tsuruga. Source: Wikimedia Commons. Specific subject.

THE ROUTE

No Direct Flight Exists — Two Routings Actually Work

Via Tokyo is the cleanest; via Osaka now means a transfer that didn't used to exist, two years after most guidebooks stopped updating.

No scheduled Singapore–Komatsu service exists, confirmed against current routing tools — every option runs through Tokyo or Osaka. **Via Tokyo:** SIN–Haneda nonstop runs roughly 6h30m (Scoot began a new daily service 1 March 2026) or SIN–Narita around 7h10–40m; from there, the Hokuriku Shinkansen's Kagayaki service covers Tokyo–Kanazawa in 2h28m.¹ **Via Osaka:** SIN–Kansai nonstop runs roughly 6h25–45m — but the routing on the ground changed materially on 16 March 2024, when the Hokuriku Shinkansen extended from Kanazawa to Tsuruga. The old one-seat Thunderbird ride from Osaka is gone; the route is now a Limited Express Thunderbird Osaka–Tsuruga (roughly 80 minutes), a transfer, then a short Hokuriku Shinkansen hop Tsuruga–Kanazawa (35–40 minutes) — a total that is, counterintuitively, about 22 minutes

faster than the old direct service despite the added change, though several sources flag the Tsuruga transfer window as genuinely tight.² A domestic-flight alternative also exists: JAL/ANA fly Haneda–Komatsu in 1h20m, followed by a 30–40 minute bus or taxi into the city.

On rail passes: the national Japan Rail Pass rose roughly 65–77% in October 2023 (a 7-day adult pass from ¥29,650 to ¥50,000) and is now widely described as no longer worth it for most itineraries. The regional Hokuriku Arch Pass — ¥35,000 for 7 consecutive days, covering JR trains Tokyo↔Osaka via the Hokuriku Shinkansen and the Thunderbird — is the better fit for exactly the Tokyo–Kanazawa–Osaka loop this trip likely follows, though its terms are due a revision from 14 March 2026 and should be confirmed before booking.³

16 Mar 2024

THE DATE THE HOKURIKU SHINKANSEN EXTENDED TO TSURUGA — THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT ROUTING CHANGE FOR ANYONE STILL PLANNING AN OSAKA-SIDE ITINERARY AROUND THE OLD ONE-SEAT THUNDERBIRD RIDE.

Between the two, the Tokyo routing is the simpler recommendation for a first-time visitor: one flight, one train change at most, and a Shinkansen line that has run to Kanazawa without interruption since 2015. The Osaka routing suits an itinerary that specifically wants Kyoto or Osaka on the same trip — the

Tsuruga transfer is a genuinely minor inconvenience once a traveller knows it exists, and the whole point of flagging it here is that a surprising number of older trip reports and even some currently-published guidebooks still describe the pre-2024 one-seat ride as though it were current.

TWO ROUTES, COMPARED

Via Tokyo. SIN–Haneda/Narita (~6.5–7.5h) + Kagayaki Shinkansen (2h28m) — one change, the simpler default.

Via Osaka. SIN–Kansai (~6.5h) + Thunderbird to Tsuruga (~80min) + Shinkansen to Kanazawa (35–40min) — better if Kyoto/Osaka is also on the itinerary.

SOURCES 1 Flight routings and times, Google Flights/prokerala.com aggregation and Scoot route announcements, Aug 2026; Kagayaki timing, jrpass.com blog (single-source figure, cross-checked against JR-East's own ~2.5hr framing). 2 Hokuriku Shinkansen Tsuruga extension and post-2024 Osaka routing, premium-kanazawa.com and kanazawastation.com; transfer-window caution, flyertalk.com forum thread. 3 JR Pass price increase (Oct 2023), japan-guide.com; Hokuriku Arch Pass terms, japanrailpass.com.au and JR-East official terms page.

TIMING IT RIGHT

Winter Isn't the Compromise Season — It's the Crab Season

A soft yen, a visa-free 90 days, and one tax change worth knowing about before departure.

Cherry blossoms in Kanazawa are forecast to peak roughly 1–7 April 2026 — about a week later than Tokyo or Kyoto — with free night illumination at Kenroku-en; autumn foliage peaks around November. Winter (November–March) brings snow and the Kano-gani crab season this issue covers at p9, with hotel rates reportedly 20–40% lower than peak. None of the three is a wrong time to go; they're different trips.¹ Singapore passport holders travel visa-free for 90 days on standard tourism terms. One tax change worth flagging: Japan's international departure tax rises from ¥1,000 to ¥3,000 from 1 July 2026, bundled into airfare with no nationality exemption; if the itinerary loops through Kyoto, that city's accommodation tax also shifts to a new five-tier structure (up to ¥2,000/night for mid-range rooms) from 1 March 2026.²

On currency: SGD/JPY sat around ¥122.9 as of 5 August 2026, near the strong end of its 52-week range (¥112.17–125.49) — a genuinely favourable moment for a Singapore-dollar holder spending in Japan, though any FX snapshot should be rechecked closer to departure rather than treated as fixed.³ The sensible combined-trip logistics, and the routing the Hokuriku Arch Pass is actually built for: fly into Tokyo, Shinkansen to Kanazawa (and on to Kayotei via the Kaga Onsen loop bus), continue via the Tsuruga transfer toward Kyoto or Osaka, and fly home from Kansai. One item this issue could not independently verify: the Hokuriku Shinkansen's oversized-luggage policy for a multi-city itinerary — check directly with JR-East or JR-West rather than assuming Tokaido/Sanyo-line rules apply unchanged.

¥122.9

SGD/JPY AS OF 5 AUGUST 2026 — NEAR THE STRONG END OF ITS 52-WEEK RANGE, A GENUINELY FAVOURABLE MOMENT FOR A SINGAPORE-DOLLAR HOLDER SPENDING IN JAPAN.

"No direct flight, a train timetable that changed two years ago, and a transfer most guidebooks haven't caught up to. None of that is a reason not to go — it's the reason to read this page before booking anything."

BEFORE BOOKING — THREE THINGS TO CONFIRM DIRECTLY

The Hokuriku Arch Pass's revised terms. Due to change from 14 March 2026 — confirm current pricing and validity before committing to an itinerary around it.

Oversized luggage on the Hokuriku Shinkansen. Not independently verified in this issue's research — check JR-East/JR-West directly.

The departure-tax change. ¥1,000 → ¥3,000 from 1 July 2026, bundled into airfare — a small line item, but worth knowing about in advance.

THE CHATTER

FlyerTalk's Hokuriku Shinkansen extension thread flags the Tsuruga transfer specifically — not because it's difficult, but because it's a genuinely new step that older trip reports and some guidebooks still don't mention.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Komatsu's domestic connections beyond Haneda — specifically Itami and Nagoya frequencies — could not be pinned down to exact schedules in this issue's research; treat the domestic-flight alternative as directionally real, and verify current frequency on JAL/ANA's own booking sites before relying on it.

SOURCES 1 Seasonal timing, itimaker.com and Japan Highlights buyer's-guide aggregation. 2 Visa terms, MoneySmart SG; departure-tax and Kyoto accommodation-tax changes, UpgradedPoints.com and Euronews, Apr 2026. 3 SGD/JPY rate, exchangerates.org.uk, 5 Aug 2026 snapshot. 4 Tsuruga transfer discussion, flyer-talk.com forum thread.

THE LONG READ

The Hammer and the Clock

A materials-science paper finally explained, in October 2025, why hand-beaten gold leaf looks the way it does — the same year the craft's average artisan turned roughly 75.

In April 2026, the Ishikawa Prefecture Foil Manufacturers' Cooperative confirmed, in a survey reported by the Yomiuri Shimbun, that gold-leaf production in Japan is now made in a single prefecture, full stop — the last outside producer, in Shiga, retired at the end of 2024.¹ The FY2024 numbers behind that headline are stark: 75 business establishments and 592 workers, roughly a third of the 1977 peak of 1,680; production value of ¥2.275 billion, just 16.6% of the 1990 peak of ¥13.626 billion. Average worker age: approximately 75. This is the industry described at p5 of this issue in almost entirely celebratory terms — the 99% monopoly, the entsuke method's physical marvel, the workshops worth an hour of anyone's trip. Both descriptions are true. They are describing the same thing from two different distances.

The rescue attempt is real, and it is not new. In May 2022, Tiffany & Co. Japan and the World Monuments Fund, working with Kanazawa City, the national Agency for Cultural Affairs and the Society for the Preservation of Traditional Kanazawa Gold Leaf, launched Japan's first formal apprentice programme for entsuke — the hand-hammered technique that UNESCO registered as Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2020: eight trainees, a three-year term, five days a week inside working artisans' studios, explicitly framed at the time around the fact that entsuke's practitioners then averaged age 70.² The uncomfortable arithmetic is what makes this worth an essay rather than a press release: four years after an internationally funded rescue programme began, the average age had risen to roughly 75 anyway, and the industry had narrowed, not widened, to a single prefecture. A grant and eight apprentices bought time. They did not buy a generation.

Ishikawa gold-leaf trade — peak vs. FY2024

Workers, 1977 peak: 1,680



Workers, FY2024: 592 (~35%)



Production value, 1990 peak: ¥13.6bn



Production value, FY2024: ¥2.28bn (16.6%)



Source: Ishikawa Prefecture Foil Manufacturers' Cooperative via Yomiuri Shimbun, Apr 2026.

Two different collapses, on the same trade, tracked over roughly the same decades.

~75

THE AVERAGE AGE OF AN ISHIKAWA GOLD-LEAF ARTISAN, FY2024 — UP, NOT DOWN, FROM ROUGHLY 70 WHEN THE TIFFANY-FUNDED APPRENTICE PROGRAMME LAUNCHED IN MAY 2022.

SOURCES 1 Ishikawa Prefecture Foil Manufacturers' Cooperative FY2024 survey, reported by Yomiuri Shimbun and syndicated via Yahoo News (14–15 Apr 2026), docomo news and Livedoor. 2 Tiffany & Co. Japan / World Monuments Fund entsuke apprentice programme, May 2022, WWD Japan, Fashionsnap and the WMF project page; UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage registration, 2020.

THE ARGUMENT

A Craft Explained by Physics the Same Year It Ran Out of Time

The physics arrived almost on schedule. In October 2025, researchers at the Japan Advanced Institute of Science and Technology, led by Professor Yoshifumi Oshima with Osaka University collaborators, published in the Nature-portfolio journal *npj Heritage Science* a materials-science explanation for entsuke leaf's extreme thinness and brilliance: hammering activates an unusual, normally inactive slip system in the gold's crystal structure, producing a distinctive texture no machine-beaten sheet replicates.¹ A four-hundred-year-old hand technique was decoded scientifically twelve months before this issue went to print — precisely as the human lineage carrying it thinned past the point a Tiffany-funded apprenticeship could reliably reverse. That is the essay's actual argument, and it isn't a lament: craft-preservation money, however sincerely spent, buys trainees. It does not buy the customers, the market, or the generational habit of buying gold leaf at all that would let those trainees become masters with paying work. The JAIST paper is a monument to what entsuke does. It is not, on its own, a fix for who will still be doing it.

There is a genuine counter-current worth naming honestly, not overselling. Nara Yuki, the eldest son of the eleventh-generation Ohi Chozaemon (see p7),

trained as an architect before founding the design studio EARTHEN in 2021 and becoming the youngest artist with a permanent installation at Kanazawa's 21st Century Museum — a real craft-and-design crossover, using 3D modelling alongside hand-thrown ceramics.² The city's own Craft Business Creation Organization has profiled a run of younger dye and textile artists relocating into Kanazawa's crafts through 2025; the Kanazawa/World Kogei Triennale drew 759 entries in its most recent edition, 471 of them from overseas — a striking figure, whatever it ultimately means for the trade itself. This issue looked specifically, and in both English and Chinese sources, for evidence that a wave of Asian high-net-worth buyers was driving that renewed interest — the premise behind p22's "worth the splurge" framing seeming, on the surface, self-fulfilling. It didn't hold up: the clearest documented craft-tourism programme, Kanazawa Ichigo Ichie, reports a clientele that skews French, American and Brazilian, not primarily Asian. The honest story is smaller and stranger than either a clean revival or a clean decline: a handful of named individuals, a demographic clock that has not stopped, and a piece of physics that will outlast the industry it was written to honour, whichever way this decade actually goes.

"The JAIST paper explains exactly how entsuke gold leaf gets its texture. It cannot explain who, in thirty years, will still be alive to make it."

There is one place in this issue where the essay's argument becomes concrete rather than statistical: Kayotei's own network of more than twenty affiliated artisans (p17-18), which quietly does at ten-room-ryokan scale exactly what the Tiffany apprenticeship programme attempted at prefecture scale — pairing paying visitors directly with named craftspeople, on

a schedule small enough that the introduction is personal rather than institutional. It is not a solution to a 592-worker industry's demographic math. It is evidence that the honest answer to "can craft-preservation money work" is neither yes nor no, but at what scale, and how it's actually delivered.

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ENTRIES TO THE MOST RECENT KANAZAWA/WORLD KOGEI TRIENNALE, AND THE NUMBER FROM OVERSEAS — A GENUINE SIGNAL OF INTERNATIONAL INTEREST, WHATEVER IT ULTIMATELY MEANS FOR THE TRADE'S DEMOGRAPHICS.

SOURCES 1 *npj Heritage Science* (Nature portfolio), 7 Oct 2025, JAIST press release and EurekAlert summary. 2 Nara Yuki / EARTHEN studio, Nikkei xTech feature and B-OWNED artist page; Kanazawa Craft Business Creation Organization interview series, kanazawacraft.jp, 2025; Kanazawa/World Kogei Triennale entry figures, *Chunichi Shimbun*; Kanazawa Ichigo Ichie clientele, JNTO regional-support case study (single-sourced).

THE LAST WORD

A reader asked for a Kanazawa itinerary in chat and got, instead, eleven sections and one uncomfortable physics paper. The honest summary is this: Kanazawa is exactly as good as its reputation says, the crafts are exactly as fragile as the workforce numbers say, and both of those things were true at the same time before this issue existed and will stay true after it. One night at Kayotei is a genuinely small piece of a much larger, much older story — worth doing properly precisely because it's small.

SOURCES, IN BRIEF — visitkanazawa.jp, kogeijapan.com, kougeihin.jp (crafts overview); hakuza.co.jp, hakuichi.com, the Sakuda Honten TripAdvisor listing, kanazawastation.com (Yasue Gold Leaf Museum); kutani-ware.jp, kutaniware.com, the Kutaniyaki Art Museum, the Met Museum and Onishi Gallery collection pages (Kutani); wabunka-lux.jp, chano-yu.com, japancheapo.com (Ohi ware); travel-around-japan.com (Kaga Yuzen); magical-trip.com, tableall.com, Wikipedia: Zeniya (kaiseki and sushi); japan-guide.com, machiya-inn-japan.com (Omicho Market); gov-online.go.jp, in-kanazawa.com, japan-guide.com, japanactivity.com (Kenroku-en); kaikaro.jp, VISIT KANAZAWA district pages, kaname-inn.com (the chaya districts); world-tourism.org, kanazawastation.com, klook.com, kanazawatours.com, beyondkanazawa.com (Nagamachi and private guiding); priorworld.com, ryokancollection.com, japanese-onsen.com, bespoke-discovery.com (Kayotei); visitkaga.jp, deeperjapan.com, musubikiln.com, here-away.com, Wikipedia: Awazu Onsen (the Kaga onsen country); Google Flights/prokerala.com, jrpas.com, premium-kanazawa.com, japan-guide.com, japanrailpass.com.au, exchangerates.org.uk, MoneySmart SG, UpgradedPoints.com (travel logistics); Yomiuri Shimbun/Yahoo News, WWD Japan, the WMF project page, npj Heritage Science/JAIST, Nikkei xTech, kanazawacraft.jp, Chunichi Shimbun, JNTO (the Long Read). Full per-page footnotes throughout. Figures and prices as researched and dated Aug 2026; single-source and aggregated claims flagged in place; nothing in this issue was invented.